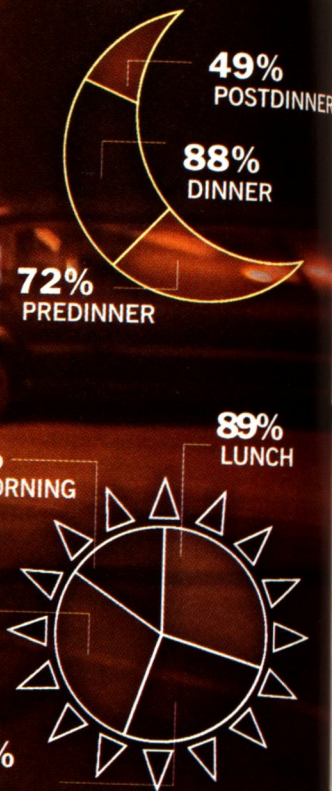


HOW MANY MEALS DO YOU EAT? THREE, WE SAY. BUT ACTUALLY HAVE SEVEN.



and eggs make an "ideal snack," 24 per cent vote for chips and Kurkure. Not surprisingly, urban India spends a whopping Rs 384 per month on processed food and only Rs 290 on vegetables, says the latest survey of the National Sample Survey Organisation (NSSO). And the top 50 per cent of India's population living in cities, consumes 80 per cent of this junk.

Experts blame it all on globalisation. Ever since India opened its economic doors, processed and ready-to-eat foods have been filling up the urban Indian shopping bag. Biscuits, packed tea and soft drinks make up the three largest segments in the

country's Rs 40,000 crore fast-food business, attracting the largest share of foreign direct investment while salted snacks, prepared sweets, edible oils and sugar are growing exponentially. In the process, our diet has lost balance and is bloated up with calories. The high-income class has added as many as 1,000 Kcals to its daily diet. "As incomes go up, the food basket becomes more diversified," shows Swarna Sadasivam Vepa of M.S. Swaminathan Research Foundation, Chennai, in her recently-published research paper.

TWO HOUR ITCH

In 24 hours, minus 8 hours of sleep, urban Indians gorge on food every 2 hours.



What's the way out? Just put your mind to it. Learn to use some tricks to keep your munching under control. When you go to parties, stand near the vegetable tray. Don't let yourself eat fast food unless you've had a fruit first. Put only two items on your plate during any given trip to the table. Chow down on the big healthy stuff and then see if you have room for the rest. When you think you will be distracted by an important (or fun) conversation, set the food down and give it your full attention. Remember, the more you're distracted by people, the more you will tend to eat without realising it. And if you are really worried about overeating at a cocktail party or a buffet, show up late—most of the good stuff will be gone.

In other words, don't stop your love affair with food. But change your life so that eating is both enjoyable and mindful.